2 RR was located (and still is) on the outskirts of Srinagar, at Shalateng/Sharifabad, opposite the HMT factory. In fact, our Officers' Mess was the HMT guest house within a rose garden. The main office and headquarters though, were in a converted poultry farm, not so rosy after all! The men's living lines had a screen of wire meshing, good for keeping the chickens in, but not for keeping bullets out. Except for the HQ elements, the rest of the Companies were deployed to cover the entire Area of Responsibility (AOR). The AOR stretched from Bemina in the South on the Srinagar–Baramulla highway to where it crossed the Firozpora Nullah to the North-west, and from Magam in the East on the Gulmarg–Narabal highway up to the banks of the Jhelum River in the West. In early 2000, units were still getting redeployed post the Kargil War. The requirement of sending additional forces to the Kargil sector had left a void in the hinterland that had been fully exploited by various terrorist *tanzeems* (groups), to consolidate their positions. The first and foremost priority was therefore to re-establish a coordinated CI/CT grid and then carry out relentless operations to neutralize as many terrorists as possible.

One benefit of having gone around with each Company was that I had gained a fair idea of the topography and more importantly, the demographics. Which areas were more likely to witness terrorist activity, flashpoints, areas of the highway more vulnerable to attacks by improvised explosive devices (IEDs); Black (compromised), Grey (neutral) and White (sympathetic) villages, over ground workers (OGWs) actively supporting terrorists and the like. All these details were absolutely essential for the planning and conduct of operations. How does an operation unfold? Let me give a real feel of the action.

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